

Word family: **lightning**

Base word: lightning

Part of speech: mainly **noun**, also used **attributively** before another noun

Related / easily confused forms:

* **lightning** (n.) — 閃電

* **lightning-fast** (adj.) — 快如閃電的；極快的

* **lightning-quick** (adj.) — 快如閃電的；反應極快的

* **lightning speed** — 閃電般的速度；極快的速度

* **lightning strike** — 雷擊；閃電擊中

* **lightning conductor** (BrE) / **lightning rod** (AmE) — 避雷針

* **lightning bug** (AmE) — 螢火蟲

Important spelling distinction:

lightning ≠ **lightening**

* **lightning** = 閃電

* **lightening** = 使變亮 / 變淡 / 減輕的過程，來自 **lighten**

These should **not** be treated as the same word family simply because they look similar.

Meaning in this passage

> Sometimes talking to him is like trying to keep up with a tiny scientist, because his mind moves at **lightning speed**.

Here, **lightning** is being used figuratively as a modifier in the fixed expression:

at lightning speed — 以極快的速度；快如閃電般

It compares the speed of Leo's thinking to the extraordinary speed associated with lightning.

中文翻譯：

有時候跟他交談，就像要努力跟上一位小小科學家的思路一樣，因為他的腦袋**轉得飛快 / 思考速度快如閃電**。

Here:

lightning speed = 極快的速度；閃電般的速度

It does **not** literally mean that there is lightning inside his mind.

1. **lightning (自然現象) — 閃電**

The core literal meaning.

Lightning is the bright flash of electricity that occurs in the atmosphere, especially during a storm.

Practice 1

> A flash of **lightning** lit up the whole sky.

一道**閃電**照亮了整個天空。

Practice 2

> We could see **lightning** in the distance.

我們可以看見遠處的**閃電**。

MCQ-ready definition:

lightning = 雷暴期間天空中突然出現的強烈電光，即閃電

2. **a flash / bolt of lightning — 一道閃電**

Although **lightning** itself is normally uncountable, we can count individual occurrences with expressions such as:

* **a flash of lightning**

* **a bolt of lightning**

Practice 1

> A sudden **flash of lightning** was followed by thunder.

突然一道**閃電**過後，便傳來雷聲。

Practice 2

> A **bolt of lightning** struck a tree beside the road.

一道**閃電**擊中了路旁的一棵樹。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****a flash/bolt of lightning = 一次清楚可見的閃電現象；一道閃電****

Important countability note

We normally say:

>  There was a lot of ****lightning**** last night.

昨晚有很多閃電。

not normally:

>  many lightnings

For individual flashes, use:

> ****three flashes of lightning****

三道閃電

3. **lightning strikes / lightning strike — 雷擊；閃電擊中******

This refers to lightning physically hitting an object or place.

Practice 1

> The tree was damaged by a ****lightning strike****.

那棵樹因****雷擊****而受損。

Practice 2

> ****Lightning struck**** the roof during the storm.

暴風雨期間，****閃電擊中了****屋頂。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****lightning strike = 閃電擊中某人、物件或地點的事件，即雷擊****

4. **lightning speed** — 閃電般的速度；極快的速度

This is the meaning used in your passage.

It is a figurative extension from literal lightning.

Practice 1 — original sentence

> His mind moves at **lightning speed**.

他的腦袋**轉得飛快** / 思考速度快如閃電。

Practice 2

> Technology is developing at **lightning speed**.

科技正以**驚人的高速** / 閃電般的速度**發展**。

Practice 3

> The news spread across social media at **lightning speed**.

這個消息以**極快的速度**在社交媒體上傳開。

MCQ-ready definition:

lightning speed = 像閃電般極快的速度

5. **at lightning speed** — 以極快速度

This is a highly common expression built from the figurative sense.

Practice 1

> She completed the calculations at **lightning speed**.

她以**極快的速度**完成了那些計算。

Practice 2

> The situation changed at **lightning speed**.

局勢以**驚人的速度**迅速改變。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****at lightning speed = 非常迅速地；以極高速度****

6. ****lightning-fast — 快如閃電的；極快的****

A common compound adjective.

Practice 1

> The goalkeeper showed ****lightning-fast reflexes****.

那名守門員展現出****快如閃電的反應能力****。

Practice 2

> The new processor delivers ****lightning-fast performance****.

這款新處理器提供****極快的運行效能****。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****lightning-fast = 速度極快的；快得像閃電一樣****

7. ****lightning-quick — 反應極快的；快如閃電的****

Very close to ****lightning-fast****, often used for movements or reactions.

Practice 1

> She has ****lightning-quick reactions****.

她的反應****快如閃電****。

Practice 2

> With one ****lightning-quick movement****, he caught the falling glass.

他以一個****快如閃電的動作****接住了正在掉下來的玻璃杯。

****MCQ-ready definition:****

****lightning-quick = 動作或反應極其迅速的****

8. **lightning conductor / lightning rod — 避雷針**

A device designed to protect a building from lightning.

* **lightning conductor** — especially BrE

* **lightning rod** — especially AmE

Practice 1

> The building is fitted with a **lightning conductor**.

那座建築物裝有**避雷針**。

Practice 2

> The church tower has a **lightning rod** on top.

教堂塔頂裝有一支**避雷針**。

MCQ-ready definition:

lightning conductor / lightning rod = 安裝在建築物上，用來把雷電安全導入地面的裝置，即避雷針

9. **lightning rod (figurative, especially AmE) — 引發爭議或批評的焦點**

From the literal object, **lightning rod** also has a figurative meaning: a person or issue that attracts strong criticism, anger, or controversy.

Practice 1

> The proposal became a **lightning rod for criticism**.

這項提議成為**批評的焦點**。

Practice 2

> He has become a **lightning rod for public anger**.

他成了**公眾憤怒集中的對象**。

MCQ-ready definition:

a lightning rod for something = 容易吸引大量批評、憤怒或爭議的人或事物

Important distinction

Literal:

- > a **lightning rod** on a building
- > 建築物上的**避雷針**

Figurative:

- > a **lightning rod for controversy**
- > **爭議集中的焦點**

This is a genuine lexicalized figurative extension of the compound, rather than another meaning of bare **lightning**.

10. **lightning bug** (AmE) — **螢火蟲**

In American English, **lightning bug** is a common name for a firefly.

Practice 1

- > The children caught **lightning bugs** in the garden.

孩子們在花園裏捉**螢火蟲**。

Practice 2

- > We saw hundreds of **lightning bugs** glowing after dark.

天黑後，我們看到數百隻**螢火蟲**發光。

MCQ-ready definition:

lightning bug = **螢火蟲**，尤其是美式英語用法

11. **like lightning** — **快如閃電；極迅速地**

A figurative comparison.

Practice 1

- > He ran out of the room **like lightning**.

他**快如閃電般**跑出了房間。

Practice 2

> She reacted **like lightning** and grabbed the child before he fell.

她**反應快如閃電**，在孩子跌倒前一把抓住了他。

MCQ-ready definition:

like lightning = 非常迅速地；像閃電一樣快

12. **as quick as lightning — 快如閃電**

Another established comparison.

Practice 1

> His hands were **as quick as lightning**.

他的雙手**快如閃電**。

Practice 2

> She was **as quick as lightning** when she saw the glass beginning to fall.

她看見杯子開始掉下來時，**反應快如閃電**。

MCQ-ready definition:

as quick as lightning = 極其快速；反應或動作像閃電一樣快

13. **greased lightning (informal idiom) — 快得驚人**

This is an informal idiom meaning **extremely fast**.

Practice 1

> That new motorbike goes like **greased lightning**.

那輛新電單車**快得驚人**。

Practice 2

> Once she started working, she moved like **greased lightning**.

她一開始工作，動作便**快得不得了**。

MCQ-ready definition:

like greased lightning = 非常迅速地；快得驚人

Register: informal

14. **lightning never strikes twice (in the same place)** — 同樣極罕見的事不太可能再次發生

A traditional expression based on the idea that an extraordinary event is unlikely to repeat itself.

Practice 1

> He had already won once and assumed that **lightning wouldn't strike twice**.

他已經贏過一次，因此以為**同樣幸運的罕見事情不會再次發生**。

Practice 2

> They thought **lightning never strikes twice**, but the same problem happened again.

他們以為**同樣罕見的事情不會發生兩次**，但相同問題竟然再次出現。

MCQ-ready definition:

lightning never strikes twice = 同樣非常罕見或異常的事情通常不會再次發生

This is an idiom rather than a separate meaning of bare **lightning**.

Important distinction 1: **lightning vs thunder**

These are related but completely different phenomena.

lightning

= the **flash of electricity/light**

閃電

thunder

= the **sound** produced by lightning

雷聲

> We saw the **lightning** first and heard the **thunder** a few seconds later.

我們先看到**閃電**，幾秒後才聽到**雷聲**。

So:

* **see lightning**

* **hear thunder**

Important distinction 2: **lightning** vs **lightening**

This is especially important because the spelling is easy to confuse.

lightning

閃電

> The tree was struck by **lightning**.

那棵樹被**閃電**擊中。

lightening

from **lighten**

Depending on the context:

* 變亮

* 變淡

* 減輕

> The sky is **lightening**.

天空正逐漸**變亮**。

> She is **lightening** her hair.

她正在把頭髮**染淺**。

> His workload is finally **lightening**.

他的工作量終於開始**減輕**。

So:

****lightning ≠ lightening****

Important distinction 3: ****lightning speed vs speed of lightning****

****lightning speed****

Usually figurative:

> He answered at ****lightning speed****.

他以****極快速度****回答。

****the speed of lightning****

More likely to refer literally to the physical speed associated with lightning/electromagnetic effects.

For your passage, ****lightning speed**** is a figurative expression meaning simply ****extremely fast****.

Important distinction 4: ****lightning-fast vs fast as lightning****

Both convey extreme speed.

****lightning-fast****

Compound adjective:

> ****lightning-fast reactions****

****快如閃電的反應****

****as fast as lightning****

Comparison:

> He moved ****as fast as lightning****.

他****快如閃電般****移動。

Important distinction 5: **lightning** vs **electricity**

Lightning is one specific atmospheric electrical phenomenon.

Electricity is the much broader concept.

So:

> **lightning** is electrical

but

> not all **electricity** is lightning.

Traditional Chinese:

* **lightning** → 閃電

* **electricity** → 電；電力；電能

Important distinction 6: **literal** vs **figurative lightning**

Literal

> **Lightning** struck the tree.

閃電擊中了那棵樹。

Figurative speed imagery

> His mind works at **lightning speed**.

他的思考速度**快如閃電**。

The second does not create a completely unrelated lexical meaning of **lightning**. It is a **figurative extension** based on the conventional association between lightning and extreme speed.

This is exactly the kind of case where we should preserve the useful expression without artificially multiplying the meaning count.

Family-extension note

****lightning**** itself has a fairly compact semantic core: the natural electrical phenomenon of ****閃電****.

Its learner value comes largely from established figurative compounds and expressions built around two associations:

1. ****lightning as an electrical/weather phenomenon****

- * ****lightning strike****
- * ****lightning conductor****
- * ****lightning rod****

2. ****lightning as an image of extreme speed****

- * ****lightning speed****
- * ****lightning-fast****
- * ****lightning-quick****
- * ****like lightning****

So this is a good example of a word where we should ****not invent many separate meanings for the bare noun****, but should still sweep its useful compounds and figurative extensions. That matches your manual's principle of searching broadly while splitting meanings conservatively.

Master comparison

Form / expression	Traditional Chinese	Core idea	
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lightning	閃電	atmospheric electrical flash	
a flash of lightning	一道閃電	individual visible flash	
a bolt of lightning	一道閃電	individual lightning discharge	
lightning strike	雷擊	lightning hits something	
lightning speed	閃電般的速度；極快速度	figurative extreme speed	
at lightning speed	以極快速度	extremely quickly	
lightning-fast	快如閃電的	extremely fast	
lightning-quick	反應 / 動作極快的	extremely quick	
like lightning	快如閃電	very rapidly	
as quick as lightning	快如閃電	very quick	
lightning conductor	避雷針	BrE protective device	
lightning rod	避雷針	AmE protective device	
a lightning rod for criticism	批評集中的焦點	figurative compound	
lightning bug	螢火蟲	AmE	

greased lightning	快得驚人	informal idiom
lightning never strikes twice	同樣罕見的事通常不會再次發生	idiom
lightening	變亮 / 變淡 / 減輕	different word from *lightning*

For your original sentence

> Sometimes talking to him is like trying to keep up with a tiny scientist, because his mind moves at
lightning speed.

Here:

lightning speed = 極快的速度；閃電般的速度

The expression describes **Leo's thinking as extraordinarily fast**.

A natural Traditional Chinese rendering is:

>因為他的腦袋**轉得飛快**。

or, retaining the metaphor more directly:

>因為他的思考速度**快如閃電**。

So the semantic path is:

literal lightning 閃電 → conventional association with extreme speed → lightning speed 極快的速度

That figurative speed extension is the key one for this passage.